A chance encounter with a rather unprepossessing raja when Akbar was twenty years old changed the future course of the Padshah's life, and the very fabric of the Mughal Empire. Raja Bharmal of Amer offered a daughter in marriage to Akbar in 1562 in exchange for the Padshah's support against his own warring brothers. In marrying Harkha Bai, Akbar gained not just a bride, but the loyalty of her entire clan, and he would then go on to devise a unique way to incorporate non-Muslim courtiers into the Mughal administration by making them respected and equal participants in the fate of the empire. Muslim monarchs had married Hindu brides before but the women had almost always had to convert to Islam, whereas Akbar allowed his brides—and there would be many Rajput and Hindu brides over the next decades—the complete freedom to exercise their own religion. The Rajput rajas and the other Hindu rulers who submitted to Akbar were slowly incorporated into the Mughal imperial service and many would attain places of the highest honour.

And it was not only Hindu rulers but a great many diverse elements that were included in Akbar's imperial nobility. Thus in addition to the Rajputs and other Hindus there were shaikhzadas,[*] the Sayyids of Barahas,[†] Sufi shaikhs, Shia Persians and many more, all stakeholders in the prosperity of the empire. A pragmatic and calculated outcome of these measures was that no one particular clan or faction was allowed overweening power over the others, as had happened in the beginning of Akbar's reign with the Uzbeks, and his foster brother Adham Khan's family. All courtiers were incorporated into the Mughal mansabdari system, the efficient land revenue extraction infrastructure devised by Akbar and Raja Todar Mal, improving upon the framework left behind by Sher Shah Sur. In this system, a unified military–administrative network was put in place, replicated throughout the empire, and based on the ultimate authority of the Padshah himself.

Akbar's genius lay in recognizing men of talent, whatever their background, and promoting them to exactly the office that suited their particular skills. Wrought through decades of learning to gauge the motivations of men and women, Akbar developed an uncanny ability to judge talent in men. From the untrained potential he spotted in Daswant, the painter, to the financial acumen of Raja Todar Mal, the military genius of Kuar Man Singh, the literary aptitude of Abd al-Qadir Badauni[‡], the administrative skill of Fath Allah Shirazi and many more, Akbar promoted men through the courage of his own conviction, even when it caused